Moon: the Earth's Satellite

The moon is located at a distance of 8, 84,401 km from the earth (Figure 2.7). The moon revolves around the earth. The moon takes 27 days and 7 hours and 43 minutes for both its rotation and revolution around the earth.

Hence, the observers on the earth could see only one side of the moon.

The moon is the fifth largest natural satellite in the solar system. The moon was likely to be formed after a Mars-sized body collided with Earth. There are many craters, high and steep mountains of different sizes which cast shadows on the Moon's surface. The light which is reflected by the Moon will reach the Earth in just one and a quarter seconds.

DO YOU KNOW?

Apollo 11 was the first manned mission to land on the Moon sent by NASA. Two American Astronauts Neil Armstrong and Edwin Aldrin set foot on the moon's surface on the waterless Sea of Tranquility on 20th July, 1969. They stayed there for 21 hours 38 minutes and 21 seconds on the moon. Michael Collins piloted Apollo 11.

Since the moon is smaller than the earth, it has 1/6 of the gravitational pull of the earth. So, man weighs 6 times less on the moon than the earth.

2.10 Asteroids

Asteroids are small rocky celestial bodies that revolve around the Sun, like other planets. They are also called 'Minor Planets'. There are lots of asteroids in the solar system. Larger asteroids are called Planetoids. These are found in between the planets Mars and Jupiter. This belt is known as 'Asteroid belt'. The diameter of the asteroids varies from 100 km to a size of a pebble. The asteroids may be the fragments of a planet exploded in the past or some parts of comets. The new asteroids are being discovered continuously.

2.11 Comets

Comets are the most exciting heavenly bodies and have ever been the objects of man's curiosity as well as fear. The word **Comet** (Figure 2.8) is derived from the Greek word **Aster Kometes** meaning **'Long Haired Star'**. They are made up of small ice particles and meteoric fragments. They revolve around the Sun. But their orbits are irregular. Sometimes they get very close (Perihelion) to the sun and in other times they go far away (Aphelion) from the sun.



Figure 2.8 Comets

DO YOU KNOW?

The best known Comet, Halley's Comet, appears once in every 76 years. The Halley's Comet was seen last in 1986 and it will be seen again on 28th July 2061.

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